

Internet Explorer 9

Internet Explorer 9 will not be available to Windows XP users however you can try IE8 from our bonus DVD

Plextor comeback

Plextor returns to the market with a 128GB SSD

volume, bass and treble settings for the speakers. It's not a very straight-forward way of doing things, but it's a nice looking control to have on your table. A much heavier remote would've been better though. The control, however, isn't calibrated proportionately – the volume shoots up rapidly in the last 20 per cent. The MX5021's remote was a lot simpler and effective. The woofer is a monster, just like the one in Sony's DB500 setup. The woofer is taller than the MX5021's. The satellite design is similar to some of the other Altec Lansing models – flat acrylic panels with the driver built into it. The tweeter is the addition seen on the MX6021.

Sony products are expected to be expensive but designed well. The Sony SRS-DB500, which is a 2.1 solution, came with a monster subwoofer – one of the largest in this test. The satellites look attractive, but they came with sub-standard cables which was probably the cause of the hiss we could hear.

The brand F&D is relatively new. Their models, the A310 and A520 came with very light subwoofers. The cables with the A310 aren't great quality and are pretty short as well.

The Intex IT-10500W don't look like desktop speakers.

HOW WE TESTED

The test system used was based around a dated Intel Pentium 4 processor, with 2 GB of Corsair DDR2 memory with a standard HD-playback capable graphics card. We used the Creative Audigy 2 Platinum sound card. Foobar2000 (www.foobar2000.org) was the player of choice bundled with the WASAPI output plugin for all the music tests. The latest graphics drivers were used for the sound card. VLC was used for the single HD video sample. The drivers were setup properly for 5.1 and 2.1/2.0 and the speakers were spaced out equally on either side. The woofer was placed on the ground on one side away from the table.

All the audio samples used were in the lossless FLAC format. The first barrage of samples included constant frequency tones ranging from the very low 20Hz right up to 15kHz. In the end, there was a 30 second

frequency sweep of the same range. We paid attention to any kind of distortion or disturbance during certain frequencies and even the inability to play them.

Next in line were the high-quality environment samples. They included sounds of the ocean gushing in and the sound of rain and animals in the distance. We rated them on how natural they sounded, and how well sounds were separated and reproduced.

The music tracks used were the elegant Tori Amos - Cornflake Girl which was a mix of piano and female vocals. The second track, was from the metal band Between the Buried and Me called Selkies - An Endless Obsession. The track has everything from clean vocals to screaming vocals and solos, to double-bass drumming and tons of instruments playing alongside each other. A good speaker should be able to produce each instrument clearly

without overpowering one another or even distorting the sound.

We used an action packed sample HD video from the movie Transformers where an army base is attacked. Plenty of canons going off, gunfire and low-frequency booms in this one. Only a good setup with an equally good subwoofer can do justice to a movie like this.

We also rated the build quality and paid close attention to the material and feel of the dials and buttons on the speakers. We rated the kind of stands used, and of course, the body of the speakers themselves.

Each of the speaker's categories were given different weights for the performance bit. Obviously, the HD movie test would be of little sense on a 2.0 speakers. In the big picture however, features was a small fraction of the entire score and performance, the largest portion.

There are a few issues. First, you need to be sitting away from the PC to be using these speakers – some 4-5 ft or so to be able to hear everything

clearly. Next, you should also be sitting at the same level as the speakers and these speakers obviously can't be placed on top of a table. The design is made to look good, as floor-standers.

Logitech's entry for the category was the Z523 which comes with a large subwoofer. One of the things we noticed was that

the woofer moved all over the place when the volumes were turned up.

The Creative Inspire M2600 was one of the least inspiring products as far as design goes. It's a model that has been around for some time now. The stands are weak, and not very helpful in keeping the speakers stable. The remote too, is flimsy.

The Tech-Com SSD-2100FM was one of the more poorly designed speakers around. The



Creative Gigaworks T3

PHILIPS SBD7000

Every iPod dock needs to stand out, with users expecting the same design and performance as their iPods. The Philips SBD7000's design is bold, and looks like a huge driver with provision for an iPod at the center. The dock isn't as sturdy as the Logitech Pure-Fi Anytime, but it is compact enough to be carried around in a back pack. The packaging for the product is designed to be like a Tupperware box.

The speaker can be powered by four AA batteries that fit snugly into the back of the product. It also has a 3.5mm analog port that allows you to connect other devices to it. It's not very loud nor is it precise by any standards. It's a novelty, and feels like a toy, which might get boring after a while. The complete light plastic feel doesn't make things any better. The Philips SBD7000 sells for around Rs. 6,500 which once again is expensive for most of us.

